

Big Upsets at the China Open as Sabalenka Falls to Bartunkova

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The China Open tennis tournament in Beijing has become a week of surprises. World number two Aryna Sabalenka lost to 34th-ranked Nikola Bartunkova, a 20-year-old from the Czech Republic, by a score of 6-4, 6-3, the BBC reports.

The upset came just one day after the top **seed**, world number one Elena Rybakina, was also knocked out. Rybakina lost to Alina Charaeva of Armenia, who is ranked 118th in the world. Rybakina had beaten Sabalenka in last month's US Open final and taken her place at the top of the rankings.

It is the first time since 2015 that the top two **seeds** have both failed to reach the **round of 16** at the China Open.

Bartunkova is having a **breakthrough season**. "I focused on myself, to be calm. She's a legend, so I'm really happy that I won the match," she said. Next, she will face Sinja Kraus of Austria.

It has been a mixed year for Sabalenka by her own high standards. She won two big tournaments in March, Indian Wells and the Miami Open, but she has not won a title since. She will also finish this year without a **Grand Slam** trophy for the first time since 2022. During the match, she did not win any of her five **break points**, and she threw her racquet in frustration early in the second set.

Other stars kept winning. Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova cruised to victory in just 56 minutes, and Naomi Osaka of Japan also moved on.

Meanwhile, Rybakina said she will skip this month's Wuhan Open to rest a foot injury. "I'll take some time to rest and recover," she wrote on Instagram.

Word Treasure

seed -- A top-ranked player placed so stars do not meet early.

break point -- A chance to win a game while the opponent is serving.

Grand Slam -- One of tennis's four biggest tournaments.

round of 16 -- The stage of a tournament with 16 players left.

breakthrough season -- A year when a player starts having big success.

Break it down

Lead: Bartunkova upsets Sabalenka
Rybakina's loss a day earlier
First time since 2015 for the top two seeds
Bartunkova's breakthrough and next match
Sabalenka's mixed year
Other results and Rybakina's withdrawal from Wuhan

Why it matters

Big upsets show how quickly the top of tennis can change and give rising players a chance to shine.

Test what you remember

1. What was Nikola Bartunkova's ranking?
 - ☐ (A) 1st
 - ☐ (B) 34th
 - ☐ (C) 2nd
 - ☐ (D) 118th
2. Where is Alina Charaeva from?
 - ☐ (A) Austria
 - ☐ (B) Czech Republic
 - ☐ (C) Japan
 - ☐ (D) Armenia
3. Who beat Sabalenka in last month's US Open final?
 - ☐ (A) Osaka
 - ☐ (B) Bartunkova
 - ☐ (C) Elena Rybakina
 - ☐ (D) Noskova
4. Which two tournaments did Sabalenka win in March?
 - ☐ (A) The French Open and Australian Open
 - ☐ (B) Indian Wells and the Miami Open
 - ☐ (C) Wimbledon and the US Open
 - ☐ (D) The China Open and Wuhan Open
5. How many of her five break points did Sabalenka win?
 - ☐ (A) All five
 - ☐ (B) None
 - ☐ (C) Two
 - ☐ (D) Four
6. How long did Linda Noskova's win take?
 - ☐ (A) Two days
 - ☐ (B) Three hours
 - ☐ (C) 56 minutes
 - ☐ (D) Ten minutes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Nikola Bartunkova: Said she focused on staying calm and was happy to beat a legend.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):